

A/sexual Liberation:

Italian Futurism & Asexuality in 20th century Feminism

JunYi (Aurelia) Zhang

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Few artistic movements actively antagonize half of the population as explicitly as Italian Futurism. Born at the dawn of the 20th century in the newly unified Kingdom of Italy, this avant-garde movement glorifies violence, dynamism, and the worship of machines, among many other revolutionary claims, to free Italy from the “weight of the past and foreigners”¹. While the precedents of modernism and cubism laid out the foundation for their unconventional stylistic choices, the increasing political awareness of class struggle and the failures of the parliament shaped the rebellious outlook of Italian Futurism. Indeed, the futurist ideology seeks to permeate all aspects of life, centered first in the artistic spheres of writing and visual arts, transforming life itself into an act of artistry that celebrates the youthful energy of revolution. Starting with people like Filippo Tommaso Marinetti, those who align themselves with the Futurists publish manifestos on various topics related to the Futurist way of life to reach the public. However, their success, or rather their integrity, is short-lived after being appropriated as the official visual language of the Italian Fascist party, given the close relationship between Marinetti and Mussolini.

Among their main tenets listed in the *Manifesto of Futurism*, the Futurists cited one more concrete example that stood out against the highly symbolic and abstract writing of the others: “the hatred of women” (*disprezzo della donna*). Just like its deceptively straightforward doctrines, the futurist’s aversion towards the female sex is full of contradictions and nuances. While the futurists value libido as an expression of energy, their hatred of women, who are often the recipients of desire, pushes them to redirect it towards forms independent of other people. They take women’s inferiority as a given axiom, yet recognize the power of women to achieve their political aspirations of overturning existing structures. Those inconsistencies, ironically, allowed female voices to shine through this male-dominated artistic movement and develop radical new ideas related to feminism

¹ Filippo Tommaso Marinetti, "Manifesto del Partito Futurista Italiano" [Manifesto of the Italian Futurist Party], HomoLacus, accessed December 30, 2025, <https://www.homolacius.com/arte/futurismo/testi/manifesti/partito.htm>.

and liberation from gender norms. By analyzing relevant manifestos spanning from the beginning of the 20th century to the 1970s, this essay will seek to draw connections between feminist thought in Futurism and radical feminist ideas in second-wave feminism with an emphasis on asexuality. Though the language and ideas about identity are vastly different across the decades, we can see how both sides accurately predict the effect of individual sexuality on the broader societal structure and return to influence personal livelihoods.

Ultimately, we arrive at the question of how, if possible, an examination of asexuality and the asexual experience can provide an alternative pathway to free individuals from gender dynamics. This is not to impose asexuality on society, but rather to recognize how existing ideas about having intimate personal relationships are dependent on one's sexual activity. In this context, an asexual lens acknowledges the assumptions made about human sexuality being compulsory and a major part of life, where in reality, people experience sexual desire in differing degrees. Early forms of expression and representation of asexuality, first championed as a way of female/human liberation, then gradually developing into its own subset in the LGBTQIA+ community, can also be seen in the writings of Futurist authors. It questions how integral sexual acts and desire are to the human experience and how external influence on our perceptions of sexuality, not just by suppressing or promoting it, but also its place in shaping our non-sexual daily interactions, can cause social and political consequences.

(Unless specified, the concept of sexuality mentioned below can be assumed to refer to the non-queer sexual attraction between two cisgender, heterosexual people with the capacity to reproduce. I will also use the word "sex" more than "gender", as most primary sources are built upon and exaggerate the biological binary.)

The Feminine, "Inferior Nation"

The fractured states of individual monarchies divided between European dynasties was not accepted as the norm for people on the Apennine peninsula, who share many aspects of language and culture that trace back to earlier eras of imperialism and unity. Even after the Kingdom of Italy was unified, sentiments of Italian irredentism still pervaded in the vicinity of its borders. Caught up in the surge of European Nationalism, the newly recombined Italy needed a new ideological and sociological common ground to unite the various states. Just as the Ancient Romans treated the Greeks with mixed emotions and exoticism, the burden of the European Classical past only further alienated Italy as a country of “inertia” and “indolence”². The glorious past of Italy, whether it be the military power of Ancient Rome or the artistic genius of the Renaissance, only provided more material for tirades of the country’s present, by concerned patriots and touring foreigners. Criticism revolved around 1) the lack of military prowess and ability to defend oneself as a unified nation, 2) the inability to catch up with “modernization”, struggles to establish constitutional democracies, and 3) the legacy of Catholicism and the church’s considerable power over domestic politics. We will see these themes outline the main claims that the Futurists later seek to overturn: the praise of militarization, the denouncing of the church and institutionalized religion, and finally, a demand to overturn parliament with anarchist tendencies.³

For a more relevant preface to the subject matter of this essay, the ethnic and social Othering of European countries that were not a hegemonic force took on explicitly sexual and gendered forms. Accusations of effeminacy for a nation appeared as early as the French Republic, coming from a criticism of feminist movements and countries that value philosophy and art over military strength. As Silvana Patriarca explored in her paper, the feminine personification of Italy in

² Cited in Franco Venturi, “The Enlightenment in Southern Italy”, in *Italy and the Enlightenment: Studies in a Cosmopolitan Century*, Stuart Woolf, ed. (London, 1972), 209.

³ Silvana Patriarca, “Indolence and Regeneration: Tropes and Tensions of Risorgimento Patriotism,” *The American Historical Review* 110, no. 2 (2005): 386, <https://doi.org/10.1086/531319>.

literature and artistic works came from both pity for Italy's plight and also from other countries that look down upon Italy's political state. As a destination of "the Grand Tour", where aristocratic and upper-class young men travel in Europe as a part of their education, impressions of Italy were similarly torn between admiration for its ancient monuments and disdain for its people. "Morally and sexually lax" summarizes this impression well, along with those who insist on the "passionate nature" of Italians, highlighting the stereotypes of hedonism and corruption in Italy. Italians like philosopher Vincenzo Gioberti also expressed his concerns about "young gentlemen becoming effeminate in their indolence"⁴, showing the general consensus of Italians being indulgent and over-sexual.

This unregulated expression of romanticism and sexual indulgence defies ideas of virtue and virility. In terms of gender, just like women in society whose autonomy is disregarded with either pity or lust, an effeminate nation can be the subject of longing or desire, but cannot be seen as a sovereign body capable of ruling itself. Regarding sexuality, while sexual activity is seen as initiated by men and modesty valued in women, excessive lust is seen as emasculating, as one forfeits social and familial responsibilities. Futurism addresses both gender and sexuality through personal and political scales. Their hatred for women and femininity testifies to their attempts to recreate an Italian identity of autonomous, hyper-productive citizens ready to carry the country towards modernization. Meanwhile, their discourse on sexuality is more nuanced: some take the expression of lust/promiscuity to the extreme and argue against any moral judgment, while others suggest transcending sexual desire, seeing it as only a distraction to productive civil life.

⁴ Gioberti *Primato*, Cited in Silvana Petrarca

The Hatred of Women

“The hatred of women,” as declared in the *Futurist Manifesto*, may evoke ambiguous responses from the reader. The disdain towards the female sex, those identifying as female, and femininity appear frequently in Futurism, even in topics where gender is not directly involved. After the buildup and context of the entire manifesto, one comes to realize that this phrase does not point its spears at women per se but rather acts as a call-to-arms for women to distance themselves from the inferiority of the female archetype that has persisted in and of Italian society for the past centuries. In a manner reminiscent of Lady Macbeth (“unsex me here”), women may enter the ranks of the male revolutionaries, to whom the manifestos are often directly addressed, by defeminizing themselves. An entire manifesto by Marinetti, *Contempt for Women*, is dedicated to explaining their hatred of women “conceived as the reservoir of love, engine of lust”⁵. The patriarchal relegation of women into the positions of caretakers and objects of sexual desire bites its own tail; when men look to their peers and partners for emotional and intellectual connection, they are only to be met with the docile wife who spent most of their life in churches and kitchens. It is much rather a hatred of excessive, lethargic romanticism, which they inaccurately named as “women”, that the futurists embraced. No longer satisfied with the idle sentimentality of the 19th century, the people turned to the excitement of the new century and its rapid industrial development; through machines, we are promised capabilities that transcend our nature. The futurists, regardless of gender identity, reject everyone who does not share this fervor; the easiest target is the women who are fixed in domestic roles, less likely to receive higher education, and therefore unable to participate in the artistic and literary discourse of Futurism.

⁵ Filippo Tommaso Marinetti, "Contempt for Woman," in *Futurism: an Anthology*, by Lawrence S. Rainey, et al. (New Haven: Yale University Press, 2009), 86, excerpt from, in *Le Futurisme* (Paris, 1911), digital file.

The obsession with youth in Futurism is to some extent linked to their worship of undifferentiated, complete life force, preserved through celibacy. Marriage is considered one of the main rites of passage to adulthood, marking biological maturity through (hetero)sexual connection. Therefore, asexuality, if present and identified as such, is often seen as exclusive to the adolescent (as is with many queer communities today); it is posed as a state of being, more commonly a “phase”, before one necessarily settles into the natural social order that allows humanity to be sustained. This sexual approach to human development echoes Freud’s psychosexual stages of development, where the growth of a person is marked by their sexual tendencies. Marinetti declares in his *Multiplied Men and the Reign of the Machine* that the “multiplied men”, a next stage of evolution for humankind, will “never know the tragedy of old age” because he “[preserves] his genital power”. Virginity now becomes not a negative prohibition but a positive trait that symbolizes the strength of one’s will, a determination strong enough to transcend one’s natural tendencies and desires.

Torn between their will to express sexual energy and their hatred of women, the futurists turned to the very center of progress: machines. The mechanical creation fulfills their needs perfectly; not only is it a product purely out of humans’ craftsmanship, but it also enables us to create something that transcends ourselves without being reminded of our biological nature. Marinetti’s ideal human is “inhuman and mechanical”, calling everyone to “drastically reduce the need for affection” by emphasizing radical independence and downplaying emotion. At the heart of the issue is the conflict between their eagerness to reproduce and their unwillingness to engage in marriage and sex. By framing human connection as a need, shame and transaction is brought to the forefront of romantic relationships and interaction between genders. Both the outward demonstration of sexual potency and the unwillingness to direct it towards specific people, especially women, ultimately point to an anxiety of being emasculated. Similar to the ancient Greeks who praised male homosexuality as an

ideal, the fraternity built upon a shared disdain of women secured a sense of social belonging and superiority.

To complicate things even further, any male authors, including Marinetti himself, advocated suffrage for women as a response to the prevailing political trends of the time. However, their reasoning often derives from misogyny. For the Futurists, women are paradoxically strong enough to incite revolution and destroy the parliamentary system that is seen as inefficient and corrupt; it is precisely women's "innate inferiority" and anti-civilization tendencies that make them the perfect comrades. However, there are unironic voices like *FuturLuce* who advocated equal rights to participate in politics for women in their *Vote for Women*, yet they made sure to distinguish between the "self-aware woman" and the ones who "wore out their knees on the prayer benches in church". Though genuinely advocating for women's suffrage, the legal legitimacy was based on selecting women by merit, which did not apply similarly to men; the male status is a privilege that only qualified women can acquire. Others built upon the symbolic femininity and praised it as a mystic source of energy; Marinetti called women an "explosive dynamite of disorder and corruption", a natural force that, despite being powerful enough, lacks direction and thus needs the guidance of male visionaries to produce a positive result. Similarly, Marinetti wrote in the first line of the Fascist Manifesto to aspire to give women "vote and eligibility", while also mentioning equal pay as an agenda in his *Manifesto of the Italian Futurist Party*. However, this must not be confused with true liberation; the futurists merely constructed another set of expectations for women that is just as restrictive as the past they've sworn to overturn. The Futurists were open and direct about the things they despise about women, or femininity; this honesty may have been the reason why there are many women who chose to join this movement, preserving the voices of female authors.

A Futurist Future for Women

The discussion on sexuality among the futurists is very much still in the archetypal and symbolic sphere of language. The manifestos are more about leaving an impression on the reader rather than providing a coherent theory on sexuality, which leads to many self-contradictions and rebuttals that turn out to be agreements. It is precisely this lack of structure that provided accessible and somewhat efficient discourse, an amalgamation or playground of ideas that even people unfamiliar with gender theory/politics can respond to emotionally. As the writings disseminate, many ideas presented through literary metaphors and archetypes in Futurist literature and art find their way back into the world with more tangible consequences. Blatant misogyny, whether it be the hatred of feminine traits or of the inferiority that women have endured in the past, created a rift between the symbolic and actual women, who are already very much integrated into social and academic life, at least in certain circles. Criticism of femininity was never about sex or gender itself, but rather reveals greater patterns of power and distribution which can reappear again in different forms, some completely unrelated to gender.

The Futurists sought to destroy every existing institution, every doctrine that is written and fixed; this also includes Feminism as it was before. English author Mina Loy, to whom Marinetti was a lover, contributed to the futurist and modernist trend with her *Feminist Manifesto*. She and other authors have refused to use or identify with the word “feminism” due to their frustration with its ineffectiveness, as Loy states at the beginning: “the Feminist movement as at present instituted is inadequate”. Similarly, Valentine de Saint-Point proclaimed that “Feminism is a political error” in her *Manifesto of the Futurist Woman*. She claims that it isn’t necessary for women to “have the rights demanded by feminism”, namely, representation in the parliament and suffrage, because it will bring

about an “excess of order”⁶. Therefore, they might not be seen as feminists, especially not in the modern sense, but as female Futurists, as the artistic movement is what they identify more with.

Authors like Loy do not argue for the rejection of sexual activities and relations per se but rather seek to devalue sex through conflating it *ad nauseam* so that it no longer makes sense to evaluate someone based on it. Loy’s idea of feminism is based on the enmity between the sexes as an axiom, that women can only be related to men through “parasitism, & prostitution- or negation”⁷; the only common ground is the “sexual embrace” that prevents complete opposition. In the past, women have relied on men as a way of communication with the public sphere of resources and fame, remaining a parasitic creature of the home. Women can also choose to exploit men’s desire for her own good, and prostitution, whether literally or in a generalized sense, can only achieve a fraction of the men’s earnings at the expense of her own health and dignity, subject to men’s fickle decisions. Loy seems to suggest negation as the next best option: taking sex and purity off the pedestal. Under the fear of losing their social standing by the slightest accusation of sexual impurity, women struggle to achieve and express the full range of their emotions and personality. They are also divided into the binary of the mistress and the mother, defined by their sexual expression. Loy’s solution was simple yet brutal: that women should abandon all sorts of “virtue” and all women should undergo an “unconditional surgical removal of virginity” upon adolescence. It might not be the most feasible nor sensible option, but it is “protection against the man-made bogey of virtue”.

Other authors chose the middle ground and acknowledged the fluidity of sexuality. Instead of challenging existing definitions of gender and sexuality, prominent female futurists like Austrian writer Edith von Haynau (pseudonym Rosa Rosà) framed the transition to asexuality/aromanticism

⁶ Valentine de Saint-Point, "Manifesto of the Futurist Woman," 1912, in *Futurism an Anthology*, ed. Lawrence S. Rainey, et al. (Yale University Press, 2009), 109, ProQuest Ebook Central.

⁷ Mina Loy, "The Feminist Manifesto," in *The Lost Lunar Baedeker: Poems of Mina Loy: Edited by Roger L. Conover*, comp. Roger L. Conover (Noonday Press, 1996), 114.

as a path of evolution. Her theory is presented through the science-fictional novella *Una Donna con Tre Anime* (A Woman with Three Souls), where she outlines her speculation of the Futurist evolution of women from femininity to masculinity, from sexual to asexual. This novella follows Giorgina Rossi, a 26-year-old housewife, in her transformation induced by a mysterious substance that scientists are tracking. She demonstrated three instances of acute change in personality. The first being a surge of libido upon encountering a neighbor she previously found unattractive, with sexual energy being equated to a new form of vitality for her. The second was the sudden decision to stride the streets like a flâneuse, flirting with people at the restaurant as a display of her energetic metropolitan persona of the new woman. In the third transformation, she speaks up in public and explains the power of the mysterious gas to the crowd with striking expertise and intelligence, resembling a bourgeois woman whose education has gained them a position in the public view as an authority or expert. Rosa Rosà then explains the transformation of Mrs. Rossi through the voice of the scientists, situating her as a universal model of evolution for the female sex:

The first [personality] manifests symptoms of amorality, individualism, adventurousness, multiple erotic experiences, the devaluation of love (reduced to nothing more than one element of a multifaceted existence) ...

Through the multiplication of erotic acts, love is devalued and thus is no longer valid to use as a metric to measure a woman's worth because she chooses to dismiss it through conflation. Instead of an act out of desire, her erotic experiences are defiance and implied to be isolated from romantic or sexual pleasure; she is encouraged to engage in more than necessary. Amorality and individualism start to break her free from the chains of familial and reproductive duties, yet she is still yet to find her place within society and catch up to the generations of privilege that men enjoyed. Also worth noting is how Futurist images of liberated women, especially in this novel, are still restricted to city

dwellers and those having access to entertainment and socialization outside of the family, often having extra time because she does not have to go to work or take care of children. The city-dweller experiences her first liberation from her traditional responsibilities, indulging in wandering aimlessly because she has yet to enjoy equal opportunities in career and choice.

The second personality ... [causes] her to appear more masculine than feminine, and extremely evolved. She completely lacks any sentimental feelings and is uniquely preoccupied with testing more and more the multiplied powers of her brain, exploring the mysteries of matter. Undoubtedly, she fell upon our era from centuries, who knows how distant from our present.

Though these traits are being unfairly grouped into being “masculine” and at the same time “more evolved”, the women in this stage find pleasure through more cerebral activities, no longer having to constrict their joy to sexual or romantic acts. In her expanded sphere of activity, sexual desire becomes negligible because it is only one of the many ways she may be recognized or satisfied. She is, at the same time, recognized for her intelligence and being seen as a full human, not mainly for her sexual value. The author praises aromantic/asexuality as a sign of liberation, which may not be agreeable to everyone, but provides a good counter-perspective to those who seek liberation within traditional heteronormativity.

Finally, the third personality provides us with a glimpse of a remote future in which, after dizzying leaps of evolution, humans will transcend material sensibilities and will witness the birth of new, immaterial senses that radiate across the Infinite.⁸

⁸ Lucia Re and Dominic Siracusa, "Rosa Rosà's 'A Woman with Three Souls' in English Translation," *California Italian Studies* 2, no. 1 (2011): accessed January 9, 2025, <https://doi.org/10.5070/C321009003>.

After realizing this transcendence of the futurist woman, Giorgina Rossi proceeds to draft a letter to her husband, all while experiencing the fourth and final instance of transformation. Like the role of women in patriarchal art, her husband becomes the abstract, elusive object of her infinite romantic potential, as she embarks on a cosmic voyage in search of freedom and the realization of her energy in her imagination. The protagonist, meant to show the potential of women in the future, exalts her sexuality and romantic urges into the abstract realm, effectively stripping herself of all sorts of gendered expression and identity. The ultimate human transcends gender and subsequently the partiality of desirable traits, embodying pure speed and energy itself. The ideal human is genderless, and they hearken back to the platonic ideas of a complete human being comprised of four arms and four legs, a balance between their femininity and masculinity.

Futurist Discourse on (A)Sexuality

It's evident that the sexuality that Futurists are celebrating is far from the interpersonal, intimate sexuality accumulating into political impetus that we discuss today in queer theories. The wider influences of accelerationism and an optimistic, enlightenment approach to technological advancement channel all human desires, not just the sexual, into wider torrents pushing the progression of history. In *The Futurist Manifesto of Lust*⁹, Valentine de Saint-Point starts with how "[l]ust, viewed without moral prejudices and as an essential element within life's dynamism, is a force", highlighting how sexual desire is not innate and fundamental to the human experience.

Like Loy, de Saint-Point emphasizes the necessity to abandon moral "prejudices" that come from history and the past in order to fully express one's vital energy. Therefore, it seemed reasonable that the Futurists, obsessed with power, would also discuss the nature of sexuality and how they could

⁹ Valentine de Saint-Point, "Futurist Manifesto of Lust," 1913, in *Futurism: an Anthology*, by Lawrence S. Rainey, et al. (Yale University Press, 2009), 130, ProQuest Ebook Central.

hone this innate energy vested in humans for social advancement. The main difference between Futurist discourse related to sexuality and our modern-day conceptions is that they believe that since sex is a manifestation of the will, it can also be freely directed and controlled through personal volition and social conditioning. Just as the politician incites the population with skillful rhetoric, the futurists also sought to promote or demote sexuality through their artistic maneuvering of contemporary philosophies such as psychoanalysis and anti-enlightenment thought.

As the medium in which the soul, or the will, acts upon the external world, the physical body takes an important role in Futurist and later Fascist expressions of power, where certain body types are used to represent political ideals and militarism. Curiously, the muscular male body rarely evokes erotic feelings as much as it establishes images of aggression, while the female body is seen as inherently sexual or provocative, requiring concealment to maintain social order. Freud himself characterized lust as a “masculine”¹⁰ entity, while similar narratives in contemporary discourse about compulsory sexuality also tend more towards using sexuality to justify male aggression¹¹. Looking back, the concept of “compulsory sexuality”, coined by members of recent online asexual communities, permeates the Futurist’s views of the world and everyone in it. Kristina Gupta defines this as

the assumption that all people are sexual and to describe the social norms and practices that both marginalize various forms of non-sexuality, such as a lack of sexual desire or behavior, and compel people to experience themselves as desiring objects, take up sexual identities, and engage in sexual activity.¹²

¹⁰ Sigmund Freud, "Three Essays on the Theory of Sexuality (1905)," UPenn Department of English, accessed September 5, 2025, https://web.english.upenn.edu/~cavitch/pdf-library/Freud_SE_Three_Essays_complete.pdf.

¹¹ Casey Ryan Kelly and Chase Aunspach, "Incels, Compulsory Sexuality, and Fascist Masculinity," *Feminist Formations* 32, no. 3 (2020): 150, <https://doi.org/10.1353/ff.2020.0044>.

¹² Kristina Gupta, "Compulsory Sexuality: Evaluating an Emerging Concept," *Signs: Journal of Women in Culture and Society* 41, no. 1 (2015): 132, <https://doi.org/10.1086/681774>.

Most of the Futurist and feminist discourse about the place of women in society and personal relationships could not escape the framework of sexuality because femininity is related or separated from universal humanity by it. The Futurist discourse about female oppression and liberation, no matter how radical they may seem, is correctly identified by certain female authors to still be constrained in the relativity that is defined by sexual desire or celibacy. Above existing tensions between the sexes, Futurists and other worshippers of the gender binary, like Freud, also take a pan-sexual viewpoint of the world. All interhuman relationships are to be considered with respect to their sexual potential; a woman cannot be both respected and retain her sexuality. All life-force and vigor sprouts from a sexual origin; one cannot love and live life to its fullest without expressing it in a sexual way.

Asexuality in Second Wave Feminism

Despite being two waves of feminism apart, authors in both Futurism and second-wave Feminism located sexuality as a defining characteristic of gender expression and subsequently dynamics. Orlando highlights how patriarchal society, “based on sex differentiation”, is built on the myths they construct around sexuality¹³. While authors like Rosa Rosà seek personal transcendence of gender roles through intellectual awakening, Orlando calls for a societal devaluation, or rather decentralization, of the role of sex in personal relationships. She points out how, unlike the fraternity between men, women are often taught to prioritize love over friendship, leaving them isolated and helpless in the face of gender-based oppression from the very people they’ve been taught to rely on. This need for companionship, and oftentimes emotional consolation, is, as with intimacy, seen as only consummated upon intercourse, leaving people to wrongfully direct their attention to sexual appeal instead of forging authentic interactions. Unlike Futurist ideas of individuality and personal

¹³ Lisa Orlando, "The Asexual Manifesto," September 1972, accessed June 16, 2025, <https://accarchive.lgbt/artifacts/orlando-the-asexual-manifesto/>.

transcendence, second-wave feminism presents a more realistic model of social interactions that is not centered around sex, yet still provides the benefits of a community. Women do still experience sexual desire, but the means to achieve pleasure is no longer monopolized by men as women find greater emotional support through friendships and dispel the taboo of masturbation for satisfying their libido.

Asexuality is not simply an aversion to sex. According to Asexual Visibility and Education Network (AVEN), one of the largest online communities for people on the asexual/aromantic spectrum, an Asexual person is “not drawn to people sexually and [does] not desire to act upon attraction to others in a sexual way.” This is, however, a definition that has been rather recently formalized and may not be compatible when analyzing earlier works that reference the idea of asexuality. The first coherent declaration of what it means to be asexual, as a sexuality and a philosophy, was published in *The Asexual Manifesto*, drafted by Lisa Orlando, born in conjunction with the radical feminist movement. It started as a lifestyle, a conscious choice not to bring sexual dynamics and expectations into relationships. It then became an identity given the broader identity-based activism of queer movements today, as being something inherent to someone instead of an external pathology. Regardless of how inherent it is to an individual, advocating for asexuality is deeply tied to wider social impacts, such as cultural attitudes and laws that prioritize family life with a romantic partner.

The sexual revolution is often associated with second-wave feminism, taking place in the 1970s, where writers and activists began to re-examine the nature of sex through a scientific lens enhanced with feminist ideologies, publishing their works, such as *The Myth of the Vaginal Orgasm* by Anne Koedt, in literary journals. Koedt’s work publicizing her discovery after dissecting female cadavers revealed that penetrative sex cannot effectively stimulate or please the female anatomy fully,

causing women to be diagnosed as “frigid” and “incapable of fulfilling their role as females”¹⁴. This reveals the phallogentric views of sex, which give rise to the many prejudices and relegations of women as the “second sex”. The very essence of being a woman is defined to be their capability in satisfying men, and it seemed like rejecting to provide sexual value is an effective albeit temporary solution to exert some leverage in the other way. As early as Ancient Greek plays like *Lysistrata*, the rejection of their own sexuality gives women power to bargain for their rights and desires. Though reflective of a greater disempowerment of women in society, voluntary celibacy is shown to be an effective way to temporarily overturn certain power structures related to sex.

Furthermore, there are attempts to sever this innate bond between the male and female sexes for good. The promotion of asexuality in the form of voluntary celibacy and self-sufficiency was born out of the idea that the act of sexual intercourse is not compatible with feminist philosophy. Among these works is *The Asexual Manifesto*, drafted and published by Lisa Orlando, a work born in conjunction with the radical feminist movement. Orlando was a member of the Asexual Caucus of New York Radical Feminists (NYRF), where members are grouped based on their sexual orientation and are encouraged to explore their sexualities together. Given this radical feminist backdrop, Asexuality becomes not just an identity but also a political statement one chooses to make, which is different from our view of sexuality today as a part of our self instead of a chosen lifestyle. Orlando’s definition of asexuality is slightly different from how we define it now: she describes a “self-contained sexuality”, while the term “asexual” right now can encompass a wide range of negative attitudes toward sex, from sex-repulsion to indifference. However, her claims about how the other’s availability to sex heavily and unnecessarily shapes social relationships are

¹⁴ Anne Koedt, "The Myth of the Vaginal Orgasm (1970)," University of Illinois Chicago, <https://web.archive.org/web/20130106211856/http://www.uic.edu/orgs/cwluherstory/CWLUArchive/vaginalmyth.html>.

crucial to modern understanding of asexuality and queer modes of intimacy that deviate from the power dynamic described in works of psychoanalysis and male-centric theories.

The *Asexual Manifesto* not only verbalizes the desire for non-sexual intimacy that is often silenced, but also all potentially sexual relationships that do not involve objectification. Orlando points out how, unlike the fraternity between men, women often prioritize love over friendship, leaving them isolated and helpless in the face of gender-based oppression from the very people they've been taught to rely on. This need for companionship, and oftentimes emotional consolation, is, as with intimacy, seen as only consummated upon intercourse, leaving people to wrongfully direct their attention to sexual appeal instead of forging authentic interactions. Unlike Futurist ideas of individuality and personal transcendence, second-wave feminism presents a more realistic model of social interactions that is not centered around sex, yet still provides the benefits of a community. The means to achieve pleasure is no longer monopolized by men, as women and other gender identities learn to find different ways to experience the full spectrum of happiness in life, not just defined by one. This frustration with how much sexuality controls who we are and how we are seen is shared across the sexes, which wrongfully echoes back as misogyny in the Futurist movement, as discussed in the first subsection.

Asexuality as Fascist Hygiene

The awareness raised about asexuality as both an identity and lifestyle should not invalidate the efforts made during the sexual liberation. On the other side, ideas suppressing sexuality and romanticism did not go unnoticed in Futurist media. The Italian Fascist party, by adopting the artistic style of Futurism for propaganda, also molds Futurist ideas about sexuality as a part of their new state. The idea of asexuality, however, is not used to promote liberation, but rather to eliminate personal choice in the process of reproduction; a decision that we now recognize as exclusively

made by the individual is framed as a state-issued, public responsibility that is inherently upon the shoulders of the woman. Through isolating and praising the morality involved in reproduction and subsequently childcare, the party seeks to reconcile the concept of “hygiene” with the intimate nature of pregnancy. As Miguel Malagrecà highlights: “The female body was a metonym for the national body, a space of sanctity (the maintenance of the status quo), purity (through ethnic and religious cleansing and regional integration), and reproduction.”¹⁵ The fascist mother is deprived of sexuality or forms of self-expression; she is ultimately a worker that produces “cloth and bodies”. The rationalization of matrimony and reproduction leaves no space for personal sentiments, and instead of the traditional affection within the nuclear family, the father is nowhere to be seen in the entire process of raising the child; pamphlets for educating mothers are now depicted with groups of mother and their children accompanied by Mussolini himself, the “father of the motherland”. Deprived of the collaborative effort between two parents in a private household, all is now under the supervision of the state to achieve maximum productivity. For women in the Fascist framework, their part in contributing to the state is best realized through matrimony and then maternity. Loy’s main argument about not judging a woman’s worth on her virginity/relationship status is supported by her belief that reproduction is a fundamental right that should not be inaccessible to her because of the fickle choice of a male. She also encouraged women to be strong and intelligent so that they could carry out their “race-responsibility”¹⁶; this echoes the rejection of love in Marinetti’s *Contempt for Women*, where romantic love is unnatural as opposed to the “perpetuation of the species”. Even Rosa Rosà’s criticism on romantic sentiments and women’s supposed lack of mental ability started with the mother’s intellectual inability to understand and nourish her son. In order to raise a new

¹⁵ Miguel Malagrecà, "Lottiamo Ancora: Reviewing One Hundred and Fifty Years of Italian Feminism," *Journal of International Women's Studies*, 5th ser., 7, no. 4 (2013): 11, accessed June 11, 2025, <https://vc.bridgew.edu/jiws/vol7/iss4/5/>.

¹⁶ Loy, "The Feminist," in *The Lost*.

generation of children who are strong and loyal to the state, the mothers have to be scrutinized and strengthened to uplift their newborn children, being the only way they can contribute to the country while being barred from positions of power.

Contrary to popular belief, women under the Fascist regime did not live the life of the traditional housewife. In the educational documentary *Alle Madri d'Italia* (To the mothers of Italy), the regime encourages women to leave their children in nurseries, managed by their factories or the government, as they work on textiles throughout the day. Women participate in production and can be seen in factories and fields, and some scenes are even especially planned to show them receiving wages and smiling as they walk home with their female friends. As men are hurled into the military world, women are encouraged to take on the more undignified, low-skill jobs that tend to be part-time errands and pay less. Superficially, by suppressing sexuality and isolating the sexes, the power difference between them seems to be alleviated. However, jobs of prestige and higher monetary reward are still barred to women, and those who choose celibacy/an asexual lifestyle still face discrimination in the workplace compared to men with families, preventing true freedom of choice. The Fascists suppress the expression of sexual and romantic emotions in the process of reproduction to dehumanize and render their people as machines that carry the weight of perpetuating the species for evolution, especially for women.

The Future of Asexuality?

In the awakening of the “feminist revolution”, Rosa Rosà identified two absurdities. One is to criticize a strong woman who also fulfills familial duties “just the same as other women”. The other is to only see a woman as “emancipated” if she completely denounces love and subjects

herself to “psychological solitude”¹⁷. With the end goal being personal happiness and freedom of choice, it’s indeed absurd to expect everyone to seek emancipation in the same way. This is why artistic movements that expand our imagination, however radically, hold such value to be investigated and analyzed. “Look for the solution to any problem in the material diametrically opposed to it,” Rosa Rosà declares this wisdom through the voice of her protagonist Giorgina. Futurism, through the liberty of exaggerated language, outrageous claims, and artistic abstraction, beckons us to reconsider relationships between different sexes and genders. Its contradictory nature helped it propagate to other countries and artistic movements, as their bright colors and bold, clean geometries can be seen again in Russian Futurism. Its visual and ideological inklings still linger in communities holding completely opposite beliefs, picking the parts that they agree with.

With the very recent recognition of asexuality, there is still debate around whether it should be accepted as a part of the LGBTQ+ identities. In many philosophies, to love others romantically and desire sexually is still seen as a fundamental part of someone’s humanity, when hypocritically, they are ill-defined concepts that are being placed on a pedestal arbitrarily. The lack of nuanced exploration of asexuality in media and the public perception is likely to lead to faulty representation like the Futurists, who use it to their own political agenda. While the world’s attitude on queerness and non-heterosexual relationships has drastically changed in the past century, it is still often seen as an auxiliary label that says more about how “normal” we are instead of how we see the world as individual agents that are greater than the sum of all our social labels.

As humans, we all seek to connect in different ways. Sexuality to some extent reflects our relationship with the Other in general, but also the significant others that we choose to assimilate into our lives. As much as we believe we are subject to natural impulses dictated by evolution and

¹⁷ Rosa Rosà, "Women of the Near Future (2)," 1917, in *Futurism: an Anthology*, comp. Lawrence S. Rainey, et al. (Yale University Press, 2009), 246.

survival, which are not experienced in similar ways across our vast population, we are also equipped with the capacity to learn and respect different ways of being, of relating. Personal decisions and sentiments are deeply categorized and shaped by social expectations, which in turn reinforce or challenge existing patterns. Recognizing these patterns can enable us to love more freely, to engage with one another authentically as much as possible. On the other hand, the demand for self-expression can be in the form of sexuality, but it also may be satisfied by many other pursuits in life. In the past, when other pathways were rendered inaccessible for women, being sexually “functional” became the main, if not the only, metric for the female experience. Both the sexual revolution during Second Wave Feminism and Futurist works about lust seek to demystify sex and, therefore, invalidate such an evaluation; they resonated with their target audience and expanded the individual’s imagination of interpersonal relationships. In the end, regardless of how much an individual chooses to engage in socially defined modes of intimacy, may this brief analysis of literature from a highly specific time and place bring courage for everyone to love each other and themselves in their own way, on their own terms.

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